SACRED SEASONS · ADVENT 2026

Week 2: Peace That Starts Small

December 6 to 12 · Spiritual practices for small groups and personal prayer

This week's prayer

God, let me hear you speak tenderly to me, and show me one road to clear for your coming.

HOW TO USE THESE PRACTICES

- This week has four passages for Lectio Divina (pray one each day, or choose one for a gathering) and two practices to lead with a small group or pray on your own. Each takes 10 to 20 minutes.
- If you are leading a group, read the steps aloud slowly. Let the silences be long enough to feel a little long.
- Offer the questions as invitations. No one has to answer out loud, and there are no wrong answers.
- Every practice is also in the free Sacred Seasons app, where you can read it or listen as Dr. Julene guides you: sacredseasons.julenetegerstrand.com

BEFORE YOU LEAD

Let yourself be comforted before you comfort anyone. What tender word do you need to hear before you speak peace to others?

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PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

Isaiah 40:1-2, 10-11

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether you have people share their words and thoughts out loud or if they do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

These verses open and close a passage of comfort. God speaks tenderly to a weary people, then comes with strength and power. Then the picture changes to a shepherd, and the shepherd carries the lambs close.

> 1 *Comfort, O comfort my people,*
> *says your God.*
> 2 *Speak tenderly to Jerusalem,*
> *and cry to her*
> *that she has served her term,*
> *that her penalty is paid,*
> *that she has received from the Lord's hand*
> *double for all her sins.*
> . . .
> 10 *See, the Lord God comes with might,*
> *and his arm rules for him;*
> *his reward is with him*
> *and his recompense before him.*
> 11 *He will feed his flock like a shepherd;*
> *he will gather the lambs in his arms*
> *and carry them in his bosom*
> *and gently lead the mother sheep.*
>
> Isaiah 40:1-2, 10-11 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. Just notice it, and let it stay with you.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. Where are you in this picture today? Are you a lamb being carried? The mother sheep, led at her own pace? Or the shepherd, carrying others? Notice what that's like. *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again, and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God about it? Maybe you want to ask to be carried. Maybe you want to say how tired you are. If you can, listen to the quietest voices in you.

Fourth reading. Now rest, the way a lamb rests when it's being carried. Receive the gift of not having to do anything, say anything, or think anything.

Carry with you: *"He will gather the lambs in his arms."*

Try this: Once today, let yourself be carried by something: a chair, a warm bath, a friend's kindness. Notice it, and say thank you.

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

Psalm 85:8-11

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether you have people share their words and thoughts out loud or if they do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

Psalm 85 remembers how God once restored the people, and asks God to do it again. Then someone listens for God's answer and hears a picture of peace. There is hope for God doing a new work in what has come apart.

> 8 *Let me hear what God the Lord will speak,*
> *for he will speak peace to his people,*
> *to his faithful, to those who turn to him in their hearts.*
> 9 *Surely his salvation is at hand for those who fear him,*
> *that his glory may dwell in our land.*
> 10 *Steadfast love and faithfulness will meet;*
> *righteousness and peace will kiss each other.*
> 11 *Faithfulness will spring up from the ground,*
> *and righteousness will look down from the sky.*
>
> Psalm 85:8-11 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. Just notice it and let it stay with you.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. Where in your life, your family, or your neighborhood are love and faithfulness waiting to meet? Where are righteousness and peace still apart? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again, and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You might name a relationship where peace is hard. You might ask God to speak peace to you.

Fourth reading. Now rest. Faithfulness springs up from the ground beneath you. Peace is not yours to make alone.

Carry with you: *"Righteousness and peace will kiss each other."*

Try this: Today, greet one person with a blessing of peace in whatever way fits you both: a word, a nod, a hand on the heart.

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

2 Peter 3:8-9, 13

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether you have people share their words and thoughts out loud or if they do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

Some early Christians were tired of waiting for Christ to come. This letter answers them with patience. God's time is not our time, and what feels like slowness is God's patience.

> 8 *But do not ignore this one fact, beloved, that with the Lord one day is like a thousand years, and a thousand years are like one day. 9 The Lord is not slow about his promise, as some think of slowness, but is patient with you, not wanting any to perish but all to come to repentance.*
>
> . . .
>
> 13 *But, in accordance with his promise, we wait for new heavens and a new earth, where righteousness is at home.*
>
> 2 Peter 3:8-9, 13 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. Just notice it and let it stay with you.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. Where are you impatient with God, or with yourself? What would it be like to receive God's patience? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again, and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You might tell God how long the wait has felt. You might thank God for being patient with you.

Fourth reading. Now rest. God is not in a hurry with you. Take the time you need.

Carry with you: *"The Lord... is patient with you."*

Try this: Once today, do one ordinary thing at half your usual speed, and notice what you see.

PRAY WITH SCRIPTURE: LECTIO DIVINA

Mark 1:5-8

Lectio Divina means sacred reading. Read the passage aloud four times, slowly. After each reading, keep some silence with the invitation. In a group, a different person can read each time. Choose whether you have people share their words and thoughts out loud or if they do this in silence. If you do each round in silence, give people time to share their experience after the prayer experience concludes.

Mark's Gospel begins in the wilderness, with a wild prophet and a river full of people who walked a long way because they hoped something new was coming. John points away from himself, to the one who is coming.

> 5 *And the whole Judean region and all the people of Jerusalem were going out to him and were baptized by him in the River Jordan, confessing their sins. 6 Now John was clothed with camel's hair, with a leather belt around his waist, and he ate locusts and wild honey. 7 He proclaimed, "The one who is more powerful than I is coming after me; I am not worthy to stoop down and untie the strap of his sandals. 8 I have baptized you with water, but he will baptize you with the Holy Spirit."*
>
> Mark 1:5-8 (NRSVue)

First reading. Listen for one word or phrase that catches you. Just notice it and let it stay with you.

Second reading. Listen again to the passage. You might consider one of these questions in silence. What are you hoping the one who is coming will change? What would you like to leave in the water? *(If leading a group, read the instructions, read the passage, read the questions again, and give enough silence for reflection.)*

Third reading. What do you want to say to God? You might ask for the Holy Spirit. You might tell Jesus what you are hoping for, or what you are afraid to hope for.

Fourth reading. Now rest. The more powerful one is coming to you.

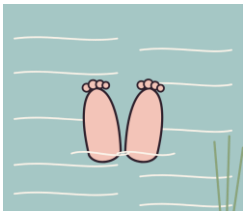
Carry with you: *"He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit."*

Try this: Today, when you wash your hands or your face, remember the water that washed you, and say, "Come, Holy Spirit."

A PRACTICE FOR A SMALL GROUP

At the Jordan

Personal, or lead it with a small group · 15 minutes



Mark's Gospel skips the birth story entirely. It starts in the wilderness, with a wild prophet and a river full of people confessing their sins. This year the church reads mostly from Mark, so this is a good week to begin.

In this practice, you enter the scene with your imagination and senses and let it unfold. It helps to picture the people as they likely were: Jewish villagers and city dwellers of the Middle East, living under Roman occupation, walking a long way to a muddy river because they hoped something new was coming.

> 1 *The beginning of the good news of Jesus Christ.*
> 2 *As it is written in the prophet Isaiah,*
> *"See, I am sending my messenger ahead of you,*
> *who will prepare your way,*
> 3 *the voice of one crying out in the wilderness:*
> *'Prepare the way of the Lord;*
> *make his paths straight,'*
> 4 *so John the baptizer appeared in the wilderness, proclaiming a baptism of repentance for the forgiveness of sins. 5 And the whole Judean region and all the people of Jerusalem were going out to him and were baptized by him in the River Jordan, confessing their sins. 6 Now John was clothed with camel's hair, with a leather belt around his waist, and he ate locusts and wild honey. 7 He proclaimed, "The one who is more powerful than I is coming after me; I am not worthy to stoop down and untie the strap of his sandals. 8 I have baptized you with water, but he will baptize you with the Holy Spirit."*
>
> Mark 1:1-8 (NRSVue)

STEPS

1. Read the passage twice, slowly.
2. With your eyes closed or your gaze resting on one spot, picture the place: the heat, the dust, the sound of the river, the crowd.
3. Notice who's there. Notice John: his clothes, his voice, what he's eating.
4. Listen to what he says. Notice what you want to do. You might step into the water, stay on the bank, or walk away. Any of these is fine.
5. If you go into the water, notice what you want to leave there. If you stay on the bank, notice what keeps you there, without judging it.
6. Hear John say, "The one who is more powerful than I is coming." Speak with John, or with Jesus, about what happened.

7. Come back to the room. Feel your feet on the floor. Look around and name a few things you can see.

QUESTIONS TO PRAY WITH OR SHARE

- What did I most want to do at the river?
- What did I want to leave in the water, or keep holding for now?
- Who did I notice in the crowd, and who might I have missed?
- What am I hoping “the one who is coming” will change?

IF YOU’RE TIRED

Read verses 3 and 8 slowly, and stop there.

> **A word of care.** Imaginative prayer isn’t right for everyone every time. If the scene becomes unsafe or overwhelming, open your eyes, come back to the room, and stay with the words alone. Crowds and water can stir memories. Choosing to stay on the bank is a real choice and a real prayer.

A PRACTICE FOR A SMALL GROUP

The Kiss of Peace

Group · 20 minutes



Psalm 85 describes peace as a meeting: “Steadfast love and faithfulness will meet; righteousness and peace will kiss each other.” Things that had come apart come back together.

In Scripture, sin breaks harmony between people and between people and God. So peace means that harmony restored, in our homes, our churches, and our streets. This practice is made for small groups, classes, and peacemaking circles.

> 8 *Let me hear what God the Lord will speak,*
> *for he will speak peace to his people,*
> *to his faithful, to those who turn to him in their hearts.*
> 9 *Surely his salvation is at hand for those who fear him,*
> *that his glory may dwell in our land.*
> 10 *Steadfast love and faithfulness will meet;*
> *righteousness and peace will kiss each other.*
> 11 *Faithfulness will spring up from the ground,*
> *and righteousness will look down from the sky.*
> 12 *The Lord will give what is good,*
> *and our land will yield its increase.*
> 13 *Righteousness will go before him*
> *and will make a path for his steps.*
>
> Psalm 85:8-13 (NRSVue)

STEPS

1. Read verses 8 through 13 aloud. Keep one minute of silence.
2. Form pairs. Each person takes two minutes to reflect: Where has steadfast love and faithfulness met in your life?
3. Then two minutes each: Where in our neighborhood do righteousness and peace still need to meet?
4. Pray for each other’s second answer, out loud or silently, in any language.
5. Come back together. Pass the peace: “The peace of Christ be with you.” “And also with you.”

QUESTIONS TO PRAY WITH OR SHARE

- Where have I seen love and faithfulness meet, and what did it look like?
- Where is harmony most broken around me right now?
- What might righteousness and peace ask of me, or of us, today?

- Whose peace am I responsible for, and whose peace is God holding?

IF YOU'RE TIRED

Alone, write your answers to the two questions in your journal and pray verse 10.

WITH A GROUP, HOUSEHOLD, OR CHILDREN

Leaders: keep time loosely, and let anyone pass on any question. Pair people with someone they don't usually talk to, if the group is ready for that.

> **A word of care.** Greetings differ across cultures, and touch is always optional. People can greet each other with a bow, a nod, a hand on the heart, a handshake, or an embrace, whatever they choose.

Sacred Seasons

A free Advent prayer app from spiritual director Rev. Dr. Julene Tegerstrand. One prayer each day from November 29 to Christmas Eve, to read or to hear. No ads, no account. You can sign up or find out more at sacredseasons.julenetegerstrand.com

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